Alicia Villarreal Villacrés

Senior UX/UI Expert · Product & Service Design · Behavioral Design · Content Strategy

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PROFILE

I started my career 16+ years ago as a developer, building websites, games and interactive experiences for brands. My first real design challenges came at Wunderman, where I learned to question the why behind every decision: something that looks good, pretty or polished isn't enough to be easy to use or to meet a goal. I kept asking what for, for whom and where it would be used, through my freelance years and into Ariadna Communications Group, where I grew from Senior UX Designer to Director of UX, leading research, product and service design for clients in telecom, automotive, retail, education, insurance and banking. Behavioral design and content have always been part of how I work; my Master's in Neuroscience and Neuromarketing gave me the science behind them: how the brain processes decisions and how to measure the emotions an ad, a notification or a screen triggers. I applied that 360° view for five years on Banco Pichincha's mobile banking app. Now I'm taking it further with an online Master's in Video Game Design: games shape behavior like few things can, and I want to bring that power, with intention, to every industry. What I enjoy most is explaining complex things simply, facilitating workshops and helping people grow.

CORE EXPERTISE

Product Design · Service Design · Design Thinking & Double Diamond · UX Research & User Interviews · Usability Testing · Wireframing & Interactive Prototyping · UI & Visual Design · Design Systems · Accessibility (WCAG) · Interaction Design · Information Architecture · User Journeys & Flows · A/B Testing & Experimentation · UX Writing & Content Strategy · Behavioral Design · Workshop Facilitation · Mentoring & Design Feedback · AI-assisted Prototyping

Tools: Figma · Miro · Microsoft Clarity · Hotjar · Google Analytics · Axure RP · Marvel · WordPress · Adobe Creative Suite · HTML, CSS & JavaScript
AI tools: Claude · ChatGPT · Microsoft Copilot

EXPERIENCE

Senior UX, Content & Behavioral Design Strategist — NOVA / Banco Pichincha 2023 – Jul 2026

- Drove 4,853 additional policy sales in 2025 (+37% vs. 2024) by redesigning key journeys and introducing behavioral interventions.
- Designed digital self-service initiatives that generated more than USD 458,000 in revenue.
- Led content strategy, copy and design for health and life insurance campaigns on Meta, including A/B image tests and a message test that converted 0.59% vs. 0.17%.
- Designed a behavioral nudge and its screen within the payments flow of the mobile banking app.
- Designed interfaces and flows on the bank's Design System, optimizing funnels and microinteractions with metrics and heatmaps.
- Turned complex financial products, terms and offers into clear experiences, working with Product, Technology, Data and Business.

UX Specialist — NOVA / Banco Pichincha Sep 2021 – 2023

- Designed the bank's first self-service insurance flow inside the mobile banking app.
- Defined the MVP for embedded insurance within a credit flow.
- Led a behavioral intervention that raised average daily sales from 24 to 52, doubling effectiveness from 5% to 10.2%.
- Planned and ran 50+ experiments, including A/B tests, concept tests, card sorting and usability testing.
- Reached 82% comprehension and 84% purchase intent in a digital fraud insurance flow.

Director of User Experience — Ariadna Communications Group Jun 2016 – Aug 2021

- Joined as Senior UX Designer and went on to lead the UX practice, balancing team leadership with hands-on design work.
- Led qualitative and quantitative research, strategy and design for websites, apps, platforms, dashboards and intranets.
- Worked with clients in telecom, automotive, retail, education, professional services, insurance and banking, including PwC, Telefónica, Toyota, Kia, BGR and USFQ.
- Owned projects end to end: discovery, research, information architecture, journeys, wireframes, prototypes and validation.

UX Designer & Web, App and Game Developer — Freelance Mar 2013 – Aug 2016

- Designed and built web, mobile and interactive experiences, bringing UX thinking into every development project.

Web Development Specialist — Wunderman Mar 2012 – Aug 2014

- Coordinated and built HTML5/CSS3 projects for brands like Nissan and Hospital Metropolitano.
- Faced my first real design challenges: questioning the why behind each decision and learning that looking good isn't enough for something to be usable or to meet its goal.

Flash & Web Developer — BANG Studio, Acid Rain Media Lab, INTEGRAS, Media Enjoy 2008 – 2012

- Built websites, animations, games and interactive experiences, the technical foundation that still shapes how I design.

TEACHING & FACILITATION

- Facilitated workshops and training sessions, in person and online, for clients and cross-functional teams at Ariadna Communications Group.
- Led and supported the UX team at Ariadna, reviewing work and giving design feedback while staying hands-on.
- Supported AI-assisted prototyping workshops for corporate business teams, guiding participants from Jobs to Be Done and user flows to HTML prototypes.
- Volunteered with Ladies that UX Quito (2021–2022), supporting the local UX community.

EDUCATION

Master's in Video Game Design — Universidad Europea · online, in progress (since Oct 2026) · Beca Mujer Ecuador scholarship recipient
Master's in Neuroscience and Neuromarketing — EIG / UIDE
Bachelor's in Digital Arts, major in Web and Multimedia Design — Campus de Tecnologías Digitales

PROGRAMS & TRAINING

UX Writing & Content Strategy — Shifta · Service Design and Leadership in the Digital Age — Colectivo23 · Marketing Reboot — M.AD School of Ideas
MOOCs (Coursera, Interaction Design Foundation): Human-Computer Interaction · User Research · Usability Testing · Psychology of Interaction Design · Gamification · Emotional Design · Gender-sensitive UX Writing

LANGUAGES

Spanish (native) · English (upper-intermediate, B2; C1 in progress)